

Preamble

Furman Pride Alliance (FPA) is a campus organization of Furman University in affiliation with the Furman Student Diversity Council (SDC). FPA offers a safe space for LGBTQ+ individuals in the Furman community for discussion, reflection, and conversation, while also providing education and resources about gender, sexuality, and other aspects of queer identity for the campus as a whole. Meetings can include educational presentations, guided discussions, queer-oriented social events, or other events that promote discourse and awareness about LGBTQ+ people and their identities. These meetings are open to all members of the Furman community, provided that they respect and abide by FPA's Respectful Dialogue Guidelines. FPA activities will primarily take place on Furman University campus, but may extend to the greater Greenville community.

Article I. Name of Organization

The official name of the organization is "Furman Pride Alliance" (hereafter referred to as FPA).

Article II. Definition of Terms

All definitions, unless otherwise noted, are paraphrased or quoted from The Lesbian, Gay, Bisexual & Transgender Community Center: <https://gaycenter.org>

LGBTQ+: An acronym which refers to lesbian, gay, bisexual, transgender, and queer/questioning individuals. The + symbol is often included to include a wider spectrum of identities, including asexual, aromantic, intersex, two-spirit, and other gender and sexual identities.

Lesbian: "A woman whose enduring physical, romantic, and/or emotional attraction is to other women. Some lesbians may prefer to identify as gay or as gay women."

Gay: "The adjective used to describe people whose enduring physical, romantic, and/or emotional attractions are to people of the same sex. Sometimes lesbian is the preferred term for women."

Bisexual: "A person who has the capacity to form enduring physical, romantic, and/or emotional attractions to those of the same gender or to those of another gender. People may experience this attraction in differing ways and degrees over their lifetime. Bisexual people need not have had specific sexual experiences to be bisexual; in fact, they need not have had any sexual experience at all to identify as bisexual."

Transgender: "An umbrella term for people whose gender identity and/or gender expression differs from what is typically associated with the sex they were assigned at birth. People under the transgender umbrella

may describe themselves using one or more of a wide variety of terms— including transgender. Many transgender people are prescribed hormones by their doctors to bring their bodies into alignment with their gender identity. Some undergo surgery as well. But not all transgender people can or will take those steps, and a transgender identity is not dependent upon physical appearance or medical procedures.”

Queer: “An adjective used by some people whose sexual orientation is not exclusively heterosexual. Typically, for those who identify as queer, the terms lesbian, gay, and bisexual are perceived to be too limiting and/or fraught with cultural connotations they feel don’t apply to them. Some people may use queer, or genderqueer, to describe their gender identity and/or gender expression. **Once considered a pejorative term, queer has been reclaimed by some LGBTQ people to describe themselves; however, it is not a universally accepted term even within the LGBTQ community.**”

**It is important to note here that the term ‘queer’ may be used in this Constitution as an adjective to refer to the LGBTQ+ community as a whole (for example: “queer rights,” “queer identity”). However, Furman Pride Alliance recognizes that not all LGBTQ+ individuals feel comfortable with this term, and no member of the community should ever be ostracized for feeling uncomfortable with a certain expression, regardless of its popularity.*

Questioning: This term can refer to anyone who is unsure of their gender, sexual, or romantic identity.

Sexual Orientation: “An inherent or immutable enduring emotional, romantic, or sexual attraction to other people.” (adapted from The Human Rights Campaign, <https://www.hrc.org>)

Gender: Gender is a social construct, defined by assigning different characteristics, roles, and behaviors to categories of people, often on the basis of biological sex. Being a social construct, gender is not fixed, and different cultures will have different perceptions of gender. (adapted from the World Health Organization, <https://www.who.int/>)

Gender identity: “Gender identity refers to a person’s deeply felt, internal and individual experience of gender, which may or may not respond to the person’s physiology or designated sex at birth.” (World Health Organization, <https://www.who.int/>)

Ally: An individual who is not a member of the LGBTQ+ community, but supports the community and advocates for their human rights.

Article III: General Statement of Purpose

The purpose of FPA is as follows:

1. To offer a supportive social environment for LGBTQ+ students at Furman University and concerned allies;
2. To support members of the LGBTQ+ community on Furman’s campus, whether through support systems built into the organization or by referring to outside resources on or off campus.
3. To provide general education about sexual and romantic orientation, gender, and gender identity for Furman University and the Greenville Community;
4. To raise awareness for issues surrounding the LGBTQ+ community on a local and global scale;

5. To advocate for issues relevant to other marginalized communities on campus in a cooperative manner.
6. To act in solidarity with other SDC organizations to provide support and advocacy for all students belonging to marginalized groups, whether by sexuality, gender, race, ethnicity, religion, ability, or national origin.

Article IV: Confidentiality

Section 1: Statement of Confidentiality

- All members of FPA are assured of and expected to maintain the right of confidentiality.
- Confidentiality entails the prohibition of disclosure of an individual's private and personal information to any other individual or group, without the individual's prior approval.
- Private and personal information includes but is not limited to the following:
 - o Information about an individual's sexual orientation or gender identity
 - o Disclosure of disabilities or diagnosed illnesses
 - o Experiences (including traumatic or dangerous) shared by an individual in the context of discourse
- Confidentiality may be waived by the individual through an express statement of consent, either verbal or written. As such, FPA members and Executive Board members should provide confidentiality for all members in all cases **unless specified otherwise**.
- Maintaining confidentiality is essential to creating a safe and welcoming environment for all LGBTQ+ individuals on campus, including those who are still questioning their sexual/romantic and gender identities or are unable to disclose these identities publicly for any reason.
- As such, confidentiality is ensured at all FPA meetings, social events, and any other FPA-sponsored event. Individuals are expected to maintain confidentiality in all outside circumstances.
- FPA reserves the right to address breaches of confidentiality regardless of whether the breaches occurred in FPA-sponsored spaces.
- The Executive Board reserves the right to waive confidentiality in emergency situations where maintaining an individual's confidential information could result in harm to the individual or to others. In these cases, confidential information will only be shared for the express purpose of preventing this harm to medical or legal authorities.

Article V: Members

Section 1: Membership Eligibility

- Any interested Furman University student who supports the purpose of FPA is eligible for membership.
- To become a member, interested individuals should register with the FPA SyncDIN page and/or FPA GroupMe to receive notifications and announcements.
- There are no attendance requirements to remain a member.

Section 2: Respectful Dialogue Guidelines

- In order to facilitate a positive, supportive, and safe environment for many individuals of diverse backgrounds, FPA has in place a set of Respectful Dialogue Guidelines (hereafter referred to as

“the Guidelines” in this section). Repeated violation of the Guidelines may result in disciplinary action, including probationary status or removal of membership. The Guidelines apply to all forms of communication relating to FPA, including but not limited to: conversations in club meetings, messages in FPA group chats or with FPA Exec members, social media posts relating to FPA or its members, and other modes of electronic communication where the subject matter relates to FPA groups or activities.

- ***The following guidelines are quoted from the Dins Dialogues Community Norms for Dialogue:***
 - **Speak your truth:** You are the expert of your own experience. Making generalizations and assumptions about the lived experiences of others can be alienating. Using “I” statements to deliver our subjective viewpoints is an effective way to communicate an opinion.
 - **Confidentiality:** “What’s learned here leaves here, what’s shared here, stays here”. It is important that this is a space where participants feel they can ask questions bravely, with the confidence that what they say will remain in this space.
 - **Listen to understand:** While we may have the urge to simply listen in order to respond and drive our point. It is important to fully understand what is being conveyed to you, both in the content of the message, and emotions that may be felt by others.
 - **Expect and accept non-closure:** The purpose of these sessions is to begin the conversation, to encourage us to reflect and to challenge some of the preconceived notions we have about others. Our hope is to challenge ourselves to think outside of our own areas of discomfort and to recognize that we probably won’t find resolve from this short time together, but to continue to challenge ourselves to think deeply about these topics and concepts.
 - **Call-out and call-in:** If you hear a statement that triggers or offends you personally, take the opportunity to call that person out and call them in for a discussion, at the time or after the session. This is a time for you to explain why the statement was problematic for you and allow them a chance to explore that with you in the safe space we created. This interaction might sound something like this, “I’d like to say that the statement you just made hurt me/bothers me/ offended me. Can we talk about it? I’d like to share why I feel this way so we can move on.” If you are called out by someone else for a statement you made, take time to reflect on how they may be feeling in the moment and listen to their explanations without judgment. The goal of calling out is not to ostracize or belittle individuals for their actions, but rather to help our community learn and grow from each other.
 - **Hold Space:** This workshop may be uncomfortable and that’s okay! Listen to your emotions. Emotions tell us stories and they help us move through the discomfort. Holding space also “means that we are willing to walk alongside another person in whatever journey they’re on without judging them, making them feel inadequate, trying to fix them, or trying to impact the outcome. When we hold space for other people, we open our hearts, offer unconditional support, and let go of judgement and control.” (Plett, 2015)

Section 3: Membership Privileges

- Members have the privileges of voting in general elections. These elections may include:
 - Election of Executive Board officers,

- Approval of organization changes,
 - Evaluating grounds for removal of membership.
- Members are eligible to hold Executive Board office, as defined in Article VII, Section 3.
- Members in good standing will be eligible to gain swipe access to the LGBTQ+ resource room, which they may access on demand.

Section 4: Probationary Members

- Probationary members are defined as members who fall into one of the following categories:
 - They have been inactive for one academic year after joining FPA,
 - There are current grounds for removal being presented against the member,
 - The Executive Board has designated the member as probationary as a result of violating the FPA Constitution.
- Probationary members may not participate in FPA meetings and will have swipe access to the LGBTQ+ Resource Room removed.
- Probationary members may be restored to full membership status if the probationary member submits a request to members of the Executive Board. The Board will present the probationary member's status at the next general organization meeting. A probationary member is restored to full member status with a simple majority vote of the general organization.
- This restoration process does not apply to probationary members with current grounds for removal being evaluated by the Executive Board.

Section 5: Removal of Membership

- At the end of each academic year, the outgoing Secretary will remove all graduating seniors from the SyncDIN page, and they will no longer be considered members of FPA.
- If a member is removed for any other reasons, this individual is barred from FPA meetings and participating in FPA-sponsored events without approval from the Executive Board.
- In order to remove a member, grounds for removal must be formally introduced to the Executive Board. While grounds for removal are evaluated, the member in question is considered probationary.
- Grounds for removal include the following:
 - Repeated violations of the Respectful Dialogue Guidelines,
 - Violation of any University policy that may result in a disciplinary hearing,
 - Any reported Title IX violation,
 - Activity resulting in a criminal charge,
 - Any reported bias incident.
- Aside from violations of the Respectful Dialogue Guidelines (which can only be enforced within FPA), all other grounds for removal are valid and reasonable even if the event considered grounds for removal takes place outside the meetings and other events of Furman Pride Alliance.
- Grounds for removal must be introduced by an Executive Board member during an Executive Board meeting, or by petition of at least three members delivered to an Executive Board member, who will present the grounds at an Executive Board meeting.
- The Executive Board will then vote either in favor of or against requesting removal of a member based on the grounds presented. If the Board votes in favor of letting the vote proceed (by

simple majority), then the case is presented to the general organization, which can then choose to remove the member by 2/3 majority.

- While a member's status is being evaluated, that member is considered probationary, and may not participate in FPA meetings.

Article VI: Executive Officers

Section 1: Duties of the Executive Board

- A. The Executive Board serves as the governing body of FPA and should faithfully execute the FPA Constitution as well as any other governing bylaws. The Executive Board is responsible for evaluating any disciplinary actions as a result of violating the conditions of membership as outlined in the Constitution.
- B. The Executive Board is the public face of the organization, representing FPA in all official capacities. As such, Executive Board members are expected to conduct themselves in a manner consistent with the purpose of FPA.
- C. The Executive Board sets the calendar for all Executive Board and general organization meetings. It is the responsibility of the Executive Board to inform the general organization of any changes to the meeting calendar.
- D. The Executive Board should meet before any general organization meeting to plan the content of the general meeting. This may include programming, education, social activities, or any other relevant activity that serves the purpose of FPA.
- E. The Executive Board determines the allocation of funding to different sectors of the budget, including but not limited to social activities, educational speakers and CLPs, and purchasing resources and/or equipment.
- F. All Executive Board offices are held for one academic year (two semesters) following the date of election.

Section 2: Duties of the Officers

- A. Duties of the President
 - The President serves as the first line of contact between FPA and the community at large, including hosting FPA-sponsored events and bringing in outside speakers.
 - The President is responsible for calling and scheduling Executive Board meetings and providing alternate dates when these meetings require postponement.
 - The sitting President may not vote in any elections except in case of a tie, in which case the President will cast a vote to break the tie.
- B. Duties of the Vice President
 - The Vice President acts in the full capacity of the President upon the President's absence or specific request, including calling meetings and communicating with the public.
 - The Vice President is responsible for making procedural motions, including motions to amend the Constitution, amend the Bylaws, or evaluate grounds for removal of a member or officer.

- In the event that the officer being evaluated is the Vice President, the President will make this procedural motion.
 - The Vice President will also oversee and conduct all elections outside of Executive Board elections, and is responsible for maintaining the integrity and confidentiality expected for credible elections.
- C. Duties of the Secretary
 - The Secretary is responsible for all outgoing communications from the Executive Board to the general organization, including email updates, GroupMe messaging, and other communication platforms.
 - The Secretary takes minutes at all Executive Board meetings and takes notes of any important points shared in general organization meetings.
 - The Secretary maintains the FPA calendar and is responsible for organizing FPA events in a clear and manageable format.
 - The Secretary should prepare a meeting agenda for all Executive Board meetings at the direction of the President and the Board. The Secretary is responsible for announcing this agenda at Executive Board meetings.
- D. Duties of the Treasurer
 - The Treasurer is responsible for the financial operations of the organization. In coordination with the SDC Treasurer, the FPA Treasurer is responsible for managing FPA's budget, making purchases on behalf of the organization, and organizing all payment receipts and check requests made through FPA.
 - In addition, the Treasurer will abide by any and all guidelines established for SDC member organization treasurers in the SDC Constitution.
- E. Duties of the SDC Representative
 - The SDC Representative is responsible for attending all SDC Executive meetings, reporting on the events of FPA to SDC, and returning information from SDC to the FPA Executive Board.
 - If the SDC Representative is unable to attend an SDC meeting, they should appoint another member of the Executive Board to attend in their place. If no other Executive Board members are available at that date, the SDC Representative may select an at-large FPA member upon approval by a majority of the Board to attend the meeting as FPA's representative.
- F. Duties of the Public Relations Officer
 - The Public Relations Officer is responsible for maintaining the social media platforms of FPA, including but not limited to the official FPA Instagram account (insert other accounts).
 - Maintaining social media accounts specifically means creating engaging posts about upcoming FPA and SDC events, sharing information about LGBTQ+ issues and other social justice issues, and promoting connections with LGBTQ+ students and allies on campus and in the Greenville community.

Section 3: Removal of Officers

A. Grounds for Removal

- An officer may be removed from office for any of the following grounds:
 - Violation of academic integrity or student conduct codes

- Violation of local, state, or federal law
 - Any act that negatively affects the image of FPA or the Furman community
 - Expressing no desire or interest to serve the organization's purpose
 - Failure to perform responsibilities and duties
 - Financial misconduct
 - Any action which may be considered grounds for removal of membership.
 - This list of grounds for removal is not exhaustive. Other grounds for removal may be considered in consultation with the Executive Board and faculty sponsor.
 - An officer may be considered for removal only after repeated violations of these policies, or by a unanimous vote from the remainder of the Executive Board in the case of an extreme single violation.
- B. Arbitration
- Before a petition of removal may be processed, all possible discussions and negotiations must take place under the direction and presence of the faculty sponsor.
 - A petition of removal must be drafted and signed by a simple majority of Executive Board members, excluding the officer in question.
 - After a petition of removal has been presented to the faculty sponsor, the sponsor and Executive Board must make a unanimous decision to approve the petition.
 - Upon approval, the petition will be announced to the general organization by normal communication channels within one week of the petition vote.
- C. Line of Succession
- The Vice President shall succeed the President.
 - The Secretary succeeds the Vice President. If the Secretary moves into the Vice - Presidential role, an election will be held to determine a new Secretary.
 - If the Treasurer, SDC Representative, or Public Relations Officer is removed or resigns, an election will be held to determine the new officers.
 - All elections relating to issues of succession will operate under the voting and election procedures outlined in Article VII.
- D. Resignation
- An officer may relinquish their position by submitting a formal statement of resignation, which must be presented to the Executive Board and faculty sponsor.
 - Before stepping down, the officer must give advance notice of at least one week to other officers to prepare for succession.
 - During this period, the resigning officer must complete all responsibilities and duties expected for their term which were previously agreed upon.

Article VII: Voting and Elections

Section 1: Voting

- A. Any current member (as defined in Article V, Section 1) is eligible to vote in elections, provided they became a member at least 2 days before the date of the election.
- B. For any election other than annual Executive Board elections, the Executive Board will conduct voting, led by the Vice President.

- C. Absentee voting may be permitted if the voter requests a ballot via email. (ballot request form maybe?) The absentee ballot must be submitted to the Vice President 24 hours before the vote is held.
- D. The Vice President is responsible for the organization and management of elections and is expected to share all election records with the Secretary for record-keeping purposes.

Section 2: Election Timing and Scheduling

- A. General voting elections (not relating to Executive Board nominations) may be carried out at the discretion of the Executive Board, depending on the nature of the election.
- B. For these general voting elections, the Executive Board will determine an election date, ideally scheduled to coincide with a general FPA meeting.
- C. The Vice President and Secretary are responsible for communicating election dates with all FPA members at least two weeks in advance of the vote.
- D. Election discussions for Executive Board elections will begin after the first Executive Board meeting in April. These will entail reading and explaining the expectations for each Executive Board position.
- E. Nominations may begin at any point after the expectations for Executive Board officers have been explained to the general organization. Section 5 will detail the nomination process.
- F. Elections will be held for the final general FPA meeting in April.
- G. The Executive Board reserves the right to amend these schedules without amending the Constitution under extenuating circumstances with a majority vote of approval.

Section 3: Eligibility for Office

- A. Any active member as defined by Article V, Section 1 is eligible for office.
- B. Students running for office who are participating in a Study Away program in either fall or spring semester the following year should consult with the Vice President to determine a running candidate to fill the position for their term of absence.
- C. Students participating in a Study Away program are not eligible to be President or Treasurer.
- D. The President may not hold office for more than two consecutive years.

Section 4: Election Officials

- A. The Executive Board will appoint an Election Official, nominated by the Vice President, to oversee Executive Board elections.
- B. The Election Official must be an outgoing senior who is not a member of the Executive Board.
- C. The Election Official will be expected to do the following:
 - a. Manually and/or electronically collect and process officer nominations.
 - b. Report the nominations and their frequencies to the Vice President and Secretary.
 - c. Keep time of candidate speeches before elections.
 - d. Record votes alongside the Vice President for Executive Board positions.

Section 5: Nominations

- A. A nomination meeting will be scheduled at least two weeks in advance of the Executive Board elections.
- B. The Vice President will restate the requirements and expectations for Executive Board positions.

- C. Ineligible members will announce their eligibility status to eliminate themselves from nomination.
- D. Nominations will be administered and collected by the Election Official, who will then report the nominations to the Vice President and Secretary.
- E. The Secretary will email nominees individually within 48 hours of receiving nominations from the Election Official, requesting acceptance or rejection of their respective nominations.
- F. Nominees have 48 hours to accept or reject their nominations. Lack of response to a nomination request will be considered a rejection after 48 hours. Only nominees who accept their nomination request will be placed on the final ballot.

Section 6: Election Meeting and Ballots

- A. Ballots will be drafted by the Secretary and sent to the Executive Board and Election Official for approval before the election meeting.
- B. The election meeting will begin with the announcement of the ballot, performed by the Election Official.
- C. All candidates are given the opportunity to speak on their behalf for no more than 30 seconds. The Election Official will keep time for all candidate speeches.
- D. Following the speeches, the Election Official will open the ballot for voting.
- E. The election will proceed as follows:
 - a. The ballot will be digitized and submitted as a poll on the FPA SyncDIN page before the election meeting.
 - b. All active members will have access to the poll once opened by the Election Official.
 - c. Voting will require the voter to enter their student ID number; the Election Official is responsible for maintaining confidentiality during elections.
 - d. The current President will not vote in the general election except in the event of a tie, in which the President may break the tie by casting a vote for one of the tied candidates.

Article VIII: Ratification, Amendments, and Bylaws

Section 1: Ratification of the Constitution

- A. This Constitution will be submitted to SDC for ratification by approval of the Executive Board and all members of the organization, in consultation with the faculty sponsor.
 - a. Ratification by Executive Board is determined by a 2/3 majority vote.
- B. Following ratification by the Executive Board, this Constitution will be ratified by the Executive Board of the Student Diversity Council according to SDC policy and procedure.
- C. Once the Constitution has been ratified, it will be made available to all members and the general public upon request and will be posted on the FPA SyncDIN page for public access.

Section 2: Amendments to the Constitution

- A. Any member may propose an amendment to the Constitution by presenting the amendment to an Executive Board member. The Executive Board will consider the amendment at the next Executive Board meeting.
- B. An amendment approved for ratification by the Executive Board will be announced as soon as possible after the Executive Board meeting in which it was approved, and no less than one week before the amendment is presented to the organization for ratification.
- C. Election for amendments shall take place as described for officer elections in Article VII, Sections 1, 2, and 6. The Vice President shall serve as the Election Officer for all amendment ratification elections, and the ballot will be a simple yes-no referendum on the amendment.
- D. An affirmative 2/3 majority vote by active members (as defined in Article V, Section 1) is required to ratify an amendment.
- E. Upon ratification, the amendment must be presented to the SDC Executive Board for approval.

Section 3: Bylaws